

JACK’S RESEARCH LAB
Research Note 003

Quality vs. Longevity in Manga Success

An Exploratory Analysis of Ratings, Length, and Fan Engagement

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Research Question: What characteristics are associated with manga popularity?

Abstract

This research note examines what characteristics are associated with manga popularity on MyAnimeList. Using data collected from 500 manga entries through the Jikan API, I compare audience size against reader ratings, publication length, and fan engagement.

The results suggest that reader ratings are positively associated with popularity, while publication length adds little explanatory power once ratings are considered. Fan engagement, measured by MyAnimeList favorites, is strongly associated with audience size, although it should be interpreted carefully because favorites are themselves closely related to popularity.

Study Design

Research Question	What characteristics are associated with manga popularity?
Data Source	MyAnimeList via Jikan API
Sample Size	500 manga titles
Popularity Measure	MyAnimeList members
Main Variables	Score, volumes, chapters, favorites
Methodology	Correlation analysis and OLS regression

Main Results

Table 1: OLS Regression Results

Variable	Coefficient	p-value	Significant?
Score	0.434	< 0.001	Yes
Volumes	0.006	0.358	No
Chapters	0.001	0.185	No
Observations	360		
R-Squared	0.214		

Key Findings

- Reader ratings were positively associated with larger audiences.
- Publication length was not statistically significant after controlling for ratings.
- Fan engagement was strongly associated with popularity.
- Favorites and members move closely together, but favorites should not be interpreted as a clean causal driver of popularity.

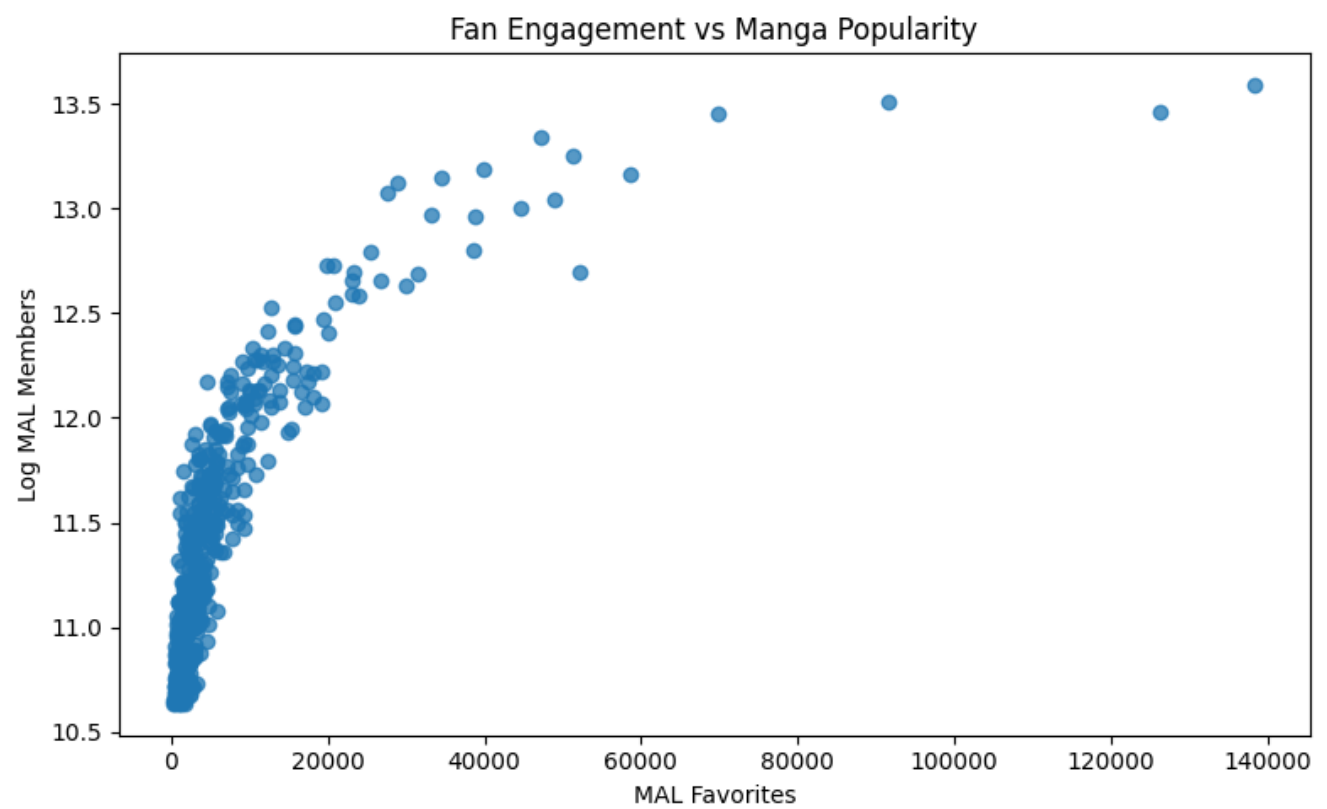


Figure 1: Fan Engagement vs. Manga Popularity

Economic Interpretation

The results suggest that manga popularity is not simply a function of longevity. A common intuition is that longer-running manga accumulate larger audiences over time. However, in this sample, volumes and chapters were not statistically significant once reader ratings were included.

This does not mean length never matters. Rather, it suggests that length alone does not explain much additional variation in popularity among the titles examined.

Ratings and Perceived Quality

Reader ratings were positively associated with audience size. This suggests that perceived quality, reputation, and word-of-mouth may play an important role in helping manga attract larger audiences.

Fan Engagement

Fan engagement appears especially important. MyAnimeList favorites are highly correlated with members, and including favorites substantially increased model fit.

However, this result should be interpreted cautiously. Favorites are not fully independent from popularity. They are better understood as a measure of audience intensity rather than a clean causal variable.

Popularity as an Ecosystem

Manga popularity likely reflects several forces working together: quality, visibility, anime adaptations, publisher support, genre, timing, and community enthusiasm. The simple variables used here explain part of the pattern, but not all of it.

Limitations

This analysis should be interpreted as an exploratory research exercise. Several limitations are important:

- The sample reflects MyAnimeList users rather than all manga readers.
- The analysis is observational and does not establish causality.
- Important variables such as anime adaptations, publisher support, genre, and release timing were not included.
- Favorites are closely related to popularity and should not be treated as a fully independent predictor.
- The sample was ordered by members, meaning it focuses on relatively popular manga rather than the full universe of manga titles.

Data Sources

Manga data were collected using the Jikan API, which provides access to public MyAnimeList data. Variables included title, score, members, favorites, volumes, chapters, and publication status.

Conclusion

Among the manga examined in this sample, popularity appears more closely associated with ratings and fan engagement than with publication length.

Longer manga are not necessarily more popular once reader ratings are considered.

The broader lesson is that audience attention is not driven by time in the market alone. Popularity appears to emerge from a mix of perceived quality, community enthusiasm, and visibility.

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